

OSSNA 2025

# The Work No One Notices- Until It's Missing

Scaling Open Source Community Management Teams

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# Introduction

Speaker backgrounds are the boring parts,
but they do help with context. So here you go!

- 25+ Years of Open Source Experience
- 15+ Years of OSS and commercial Community Management Experience
- Currently Community Manager for CHAOSS and InnerSource Commons Foundation
- Published Author
- Freelance Nature Photographer



**ELIZABETH BARRON**
Community Manager

# Community Management is Amorphous



Q: What does a community manager do?

Photo by Adrien Converse on Unsplash

# Community Management is Amorphous



Q: What does a community manager do?

A: It depends on who you ask.

Photo by Adrien Converse on Unsplash

# Common Community Management Responsibilities

- contributor (or user, customer) experience
- social media management
- blog writing
- producing podcasts
- data analytics and reporting
- moderating online spaces
- event planning
- hosting informational webinars and creating educational videos
- answering support tickets
- sending swag to people
- representing the product or project at conferences
- onboarding new contributors (or users, customers)
- documentation
- contributor (or user, customer) recognition and appreciation
- sponsoring and publicly supporting other initiatives
- newsletters and email management
- meeting facilitation and coordination
- public relations
- community infrastructure
- enabling local community advocacy and outreach programs
- surveying the community and collecting feedback



No matter how you slice it, this is a significant amount to manage!

Photo by Marcin Simonides on Unsplash

# Common Community Management Responsibilities





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# Scaling Starts Here: From One Job to a Sustainable Team

- Mitigates burnout as the community grows
- Improves quality through specialization
- Better responsiveness to community needs
- Reduces single points of failure
- Improves strategic focus and capacity
- Facilitates contributions from others



Spreading the work around is the only way to make the work truly sustainable.

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# Your First Four Roles: Building Blocks for Sustainable Growth

- **Community Caretaker**
- **Content Creator**
- **Growth Driver**
- **Organizer**



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# Community Caretaker

This role requires **hands-on engagement** with the current community, with the goal of fostering and nurturing a **welcoming and inclusive space.** It involves a lot of personal relationship building and interactions, and might include these various functions:




- **contributor (or user, customer) experience** (ensuring voices are heard, creating an exemplary experience)
- **moderating online spaces** (conflict resolution, handling bad actors)
- **onboarding new contributors (or users, customers)** (making things easy to find, being a point of contact for newcomers)
- **contributor (or user, customer) recognition and appreciation** (keeping up with who is contributing, badging or other recognition programs)
- **public relations** (diffusing difficult public situations)
- **sending swag to people** (ordering, tracking, sending)
- **surveying the community** (gathering feedback and insight)

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# Content Creator

The goal of this role is to **inform, educate, and entertain** through **creative content**. A love of writing and other various forms of content creation helps perform functions like:

- **blog writing** (SEO friendly, timely, interesting articles)
- **producing podcasts** (hosting, inviting, scheduling, recording, promoting)
- **creating videos and hosting informational webinars** (educating the community)
- **documentation** (educating the community)
- **newsletters and email list management** (keeping the community informed, understanding spam and email lists of subscribers)




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# Growth Driver

This role is focused on **outreach** and bringing new faces into the community. It entails a mix of **writing and public-facing** activities. This person might be responsible for:

- **social media management** (understanding platforms, keeping up with trends and mentions, posting events)
- **sponsoring and publicly supporting other initiatives** (building goodwill and partnerships with others)
- **representing the product or project at conferences** (staffing the booth, setting up/tear down, organizing other volunteers, ordering signage)
- **running an ambassador or partner program** (managing applications, organizing volunteers, sending swag



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# Community Organizer

This **behind-the-scenes role** requires someone that is very organized and detail-oriented. Although equal in importance, this role is the the **support mechanism for the other three roles**, and the glue that holds them together. Responsibilities might include:

- **data analytics and reporting** (building dashboards, keeping up with trends and metrics, reporting to leadership)
- **meeting facilitation and coordination** (maintaining a calendar, managing conferencing apps and recordings)
- **event planning** (coordinating volunteers, venue, catering, schedule, registrations, sponsorships, CFPs, speakers)
- **supporting local meetups and groups** (offering support, maintainting calendar, sending swag)
- **community infrastructure** (administering various communication platforms, tools)
- **website management (**keeping the website up to date)




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# Growing the Team in a Perfect World™




## Inclusive Culture = Sustainability

True community growth starts with care. By beginning with a Community Caretaker, you create the conditions for people to feel seen, supported, and invested. This lays the foundation for lasting engagement, organic advocacy, and a community that grows and retains its pool of contributors.

# Growing the Team with Limited Resources




## Limited Resources = Strategic Shift

With limited resources, there is a temptation to concetrate on bringing more people into the fold. But growing the community prematurely can have devastating and long-lasting effects on future community building efforts.

It takes a deliberate and mindful strategy and creative use of the resources you do have.

# Common Community Management Responsibilities

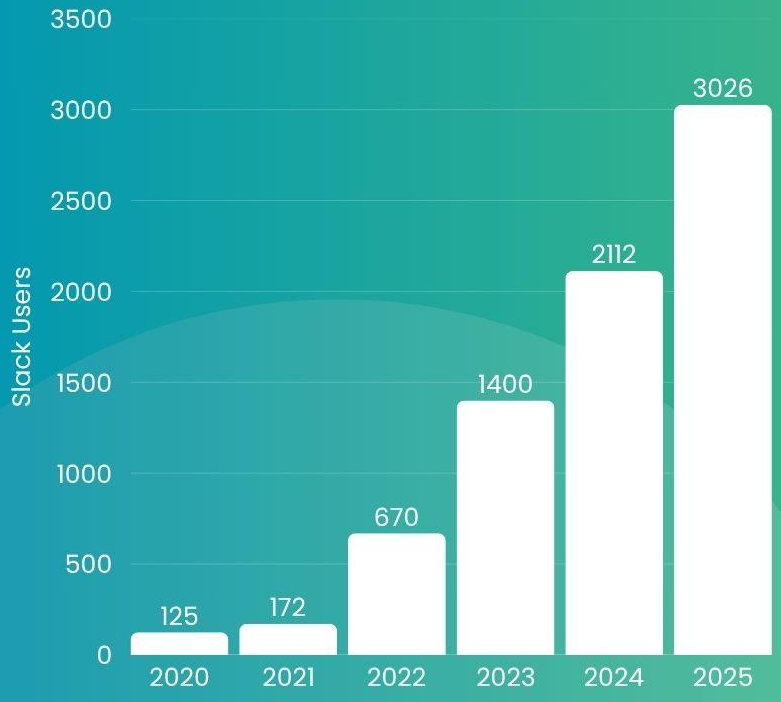
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# Measuring The Results




CASE STUDY

## CHAOSS

In CHAOSS, community work is not the burden of one, but the practice of many. Care lives at the core of what we build together and shows up in how we interact with one another every day.

Growing the community really wasn't our focus, but it was a natural by-product.

# Conclusion



## 3 things to remember:

1. Starting with care builds a foundation of **trust, belonging, and vested interest,** and makes everything else easier
2. Community building as a **team sport** allows for **scalability, specialization, responsiveness and strategic thinking**.
3. Building a community and scaling a community management team just takes **time**.

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# Thank You!



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